



Support systems: Rajat Patidar credits RCB mentor and batting coach Dinesh Karthik and Madhya Pradesh head coach Chandrakant Pandit for sharpening both his cricketing skills and understanding of the game.

K. MURALIKUMAR

preferred length, etc. But that only tells us a story. We should be flexible to make decisions based on his form on the day and the conditions on offer," the captain says.

The IPL has also seen a sharp rise in players being signed directly after strong performances in State leagues, sometimes even before making their domestic debuts. Patidar believes this direct pathway is crucial in the shortest format.

"When there were no leagues around, only 10-15 players were

playing domestic cricket, and often it was the same set of players playing across formats. There are so many players in India waiting for a chance in T20s. Leagues give these deserving individuals a chance to show their talent. To bring these players up, we need to increase the number of matches they play," Patidar reckons.

"I try to involve them as much as possible during practice sessions. We need to ensure they don't stray from what brought them to this level," he adds.

The batting evolution

Since 2024, among Indian batters who have played at least 15 IPL games, Patidar has the fourth-highest strike rate (169.75). The three names above him, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Abhishek

Sharma and Priyansh Arya, are opening batters who benefit from field restrictions for six overs.

The RCB No. 4 says he has always batted briskly, but outlined the work he put in to elevate his T20 game to its current level.

"My batting was of the multi-day mould while growing up, but I still had a good strike rate in this format. I have been able to get that clarity on how to bat across formats. I worked on my T20 game and tried to add to my strengths. The shots I can play now are because I have been practising them for years. People say I play spin very well, but I actually enjoy playing pace more," he says.

But how does one attain that clarity? According to Patidar, there is no substitute for experience.

"Very few players manage to

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Most famous contact on your phone?

Faf du Plessis

One thing you like and dislike about Virat Kohli?

I like his energy. There is nothing I don't like. He's my idol

If you can add/change one rule in cricket, what would it be?

Remove the Impact Player rule